

Optical viewfinder: See Viewfinder.

Optical Zoom: A zoom lens that uses movement of lens elements to achieve various fields of view. Regardless of whether the zoom is set for wide angle or telephoto viewing, the resolution of the image remains the same.

Orientation sensor: A sensor that knows when you turn the camera to take a vertical shot and rotates the picture so it won't be displayed on its side when you view it.

Overexposure: Exposing the image sensor to more light than is needed to render the scene as the eye sees it. Results in too light a photograph.

PAL: A European video-out standard to display images on a TV screen.

Panorama: A photograph with much wider horizontal coverage than a normal photograph, up to 360 degrees and more.

Panoramic mode: A digital camera mode that uses just the centre band on the image sensor to capture an image that is much wider than it is tall.

Parallax: An effect seen in close-up photography when the viewfinder is offset by some distance from the lens. The scene through the viewfinder is offset from the scene through the lens.

Parallel port: A port on the computer that is faster than a serial port but slower than SCSI, USB, or IEEE 1394 ports. Often used by printers and flash card readers.

PC card: A card, in the case of cameras usually a storage device, that plugs into a slot in a notebook or hand-held computer. Originally called PCMCIA cards.

PCMCIA card: See PC Card.

PDF files: Adobe's Portable Document Format is a translation format